

A Bright Line That Binds on Few: The NBA's 65-Game Rule and Star Availability

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Abstract

In 2023-24 the NBA made eligibility for its major individual awards conditional on appearing in 65 regular-season games of at least 20 minutes. The rule is a notch, and notches predict bunching at the threshold, play-through by players just short of it, and more rest once eligibility is secured or out of reach. Using every player-game from 2013-14 through 2025-26, I test each prediction against the players who meet the league's own definition of a star and find no mark on games played. There is no excess mass at 65. Stars near the line late in the season were no more likely to cross it. Star availability relative to comparable players defined on prior-season status changed by -0.8 games (SE 2.3) after the rule, with a minimum detectable effect of 6.5 games, and the raw rise in star games in the rule's first season was half a change in who the stars were and half a within-player swing of a size seen before the rule. Late-season absence by stars who had played the previous game shows the same injury-driven gradient across eligibility states before and after the rule. The explanation is arithmetic: only a quarter of stars are within reach of the line in the season's last weeks, and a full response by all of them would add at most 0.7 to 1.3 games to the star mean. The one detectable effect is on minutes. The share of star appearances lasting 20 or more minutes rose 4.6 percentage points (SE 1.0) relative to the control group, which did not move. I also document that ESPN box scores omit players on the inactive list, so absence must be measured on the schedule rather than on box-score rows.

JEL codes: J22, J33, Z22, H24, D91.

Keywords: notches, bunching, awards, tournaments, labor supply, load management, National Basketball Association.

1 Introduction

In April 2024 the NBA commissioner reported that games missed by star players had fallen about 15 percent in the first season of the league’s 65-game award-eligibility rule (Sportico 2024). The raw numbers agree: stars averaged 59.4 games in 2022-23 and 65.0 in 2023-24 [tab1_sample]. Half of that rise was a change in who the stars were. The seven players who entered the star set in 2023-24 averaged 69.6 games and the six who left had averaged 46.7 the season before. The 39 players who were stars in both seasons played 2.9 more games, a within-player rise of a size the same comparison had produced from 2015 to 2016 and would produce, in the other direction, from 2025 to 2026 [tabA8_composition_2024; tabA9_cohort_pairs]. This paper asks whether the rule changed star behavior at all, and answers with bounds.

The rule is a notch in the sense of Kleven and Waseem (2013). To be eligible for Most Valuable Player, Defensive Player of the Year, and the All-NBA and All-Defensive teams, a player must appear in 65 regular-season games of at least 20 minutes, with an allowance of two games between 15 and 19 minutes. Below the line the award system offers nothing; at the line it offers full eligibility. Notches predict mass at the threshold, play-through by agents just short of it, and slack once eligibility is either secured or out of reach. The direction of these predictions does not depend on the size of the prize; the magnitude does, which is why Section 7 counts the players for whom the prize is large and pivotal. Where that population is thin, the bunching literature has long recognized that no visible response should be expected (Saez 2010; Chetty et al. 2011; Kleven 2016).

I test each prediction on every player-game from 2013-14 through 2025-26, for the 36 to 46 players per season who meet the league’s own definition of a star. There is no excess mass at 65. Stars within a few games of the line late in the season were no more likely to cross it after the rule than before. Star availability relative to a control group defined on prior-season status did not change in any post-rule season; the pooled estimate for games played is -0.8 (SE 2.3) with a minimum detectable effect of 6.5 games. Late-season absence among stars who had played the previous game did not rise in the states where the rule removes the incentive to play. The reason is that the rule can matter only to the quarter of stars within reach of the line in the season’s final weeks, and a complete response by all of them would add between 0.7 and 1.3 games to the star mean, inside every interval reported. Star absence is dominated by spells of ten or more games, which the rule does not touch. The one detectable effect is on minutes: after the rule, stars almost never appear for fewer than 20 minutes, and the share of their appearances that qualify rose 4.6 points (SE 1.0) relative to the control, which did not move.

The paper makes three contributions. To my knowledge it is the first econometric evaluation of the rule or of the Player Participation Policy (PPP) adopted alongside it; the nearest academic work studies the performance effects of rest by age and cites the policy only as motivation (Nakamura-Sakai, Forastiere, and Macdonald 2024). To the literature on notches it adds a case in which a clean notch with real stakes produced no detectable response on the targeted margin and a detectable response on an adjacent one, and it traces the null to the size of the population at the margin

rather than to a zero elasticity. And it documents, for users of ESPN box scores, that the source carries only players on the active list, so that absence must be measured on the schedule.

Section 2 reviews the rule, the policies around it, and the literatures the paper draws on. Section 3 sets out a simple model. Section 4 describes the data. Sections 5 and 6 report availability and absence results. Section 7 formalizes the mechanisms and reports the minutes effect. Section 8 discusses what the results do and do not show.

2 Background

The rule and the policies around it

Figure 1 places the policies on a timeline. The 65-game rule was ratified in the April 2023 collective bargaining agreement and applied from 2023-24. A game counts if the player plays at least 20 minutes; up to two games of 15 to 19 minutes also count. Rookie of the Year is exempt (ESPN 2023b). The in-season tournament final counts toward the threshold although it is excluded from regular-season statistics (Sports Illustrated 2026). There is an exception for season-ending injuries after 62 qualifying games and a provision for extraordinary circumstances. In April 2026 the league and the union ruled two players eligible under that provision, one at 64 qualifying games who missed two games for the birth of a child and one at 63 after a collapsed lung, while a third, at 60, took his case to an arbitrator and lost (ESPN 2026; Forbes 2026). My counts for those three players are 64, 63, and 60 [waiver_cases_2026.csv]. A fourth player reached 65 in the season’s penultimate game by playing 26 minutes through bruised ribs, his 64 regular-season games plus the tournament final (FOX Sports 2026); my count is 64 regular-season games and 65 under the rule [tabA5_bbr_validation].

The stakes are large for a minority. All-NBA selection triggers salary escalators and eligibility for the largest contract tiers, and one player’s exclusion from the 2023 teams was reported to cost him 39 million dollars over five seasons (Sportico 2023). For the median star the stakes are smaller: an All-NBA third team is a distinction, and Sixth Man or Most Improved is not a target for a player already recognized as a star.

The rule was written against a specific fact: in 2023, five of the fifteen All-NBA selections had played fewer than 65 games (Hoops Rumors 2024a). The PPP took effect in the same season. It defines a star as a player selected to an All-Star or All-NBA team in any of the prior three seasons, requires teams to keep healthy stars available for nationally televised and tournament games, forbids resting two stars in one game, requires a balance of home and road absences, bars long shutdowns of healthy players, and fines teams 100,000 dollars for a first violation, 250,000 for a second, and one million more than the previous penalty thereafter (NBA 2023; ESPN 2023a). A resting policy adopted in September 2017 already barred resting healthy players on national television and resting several players at once, and the league restated it twice before the PPP. A November 2019 memo barred teams from labeling a healthy player’s absence ‘load management,’ reserving ‘rest’ for that case and reminding teams that healthy players could not sit high-profile televised games; the

Clippers were fined 50,000 dollars that month over statements about Kawhi Leonard’s health that the league found inconsistent with his status (ESPN 2019; CBS Sports 2019). A December 2020 memo for the condensed pandemic season reaffirmed the television-game prohibition, with a fine of at least 100,000 dollars, while allowing rest in non-televised games for back-to-backs, veterans coming off a long playoff run, and players recovering from COVID-19 (ESPN 2020; NBC Sports 2020). The PPP’s additions in 2023 were the star definition, the escalating fines, the roster-balance and no-shutdown provisions, and enforcement (ESPN 2023b). The PPP acts on the team, not the player.

Notches, bunching, and thresholds in sport

Saez (2010) compared the density of taxable income around kink points with a smooth counterfactual and recovered elasticities from the excess mass; his headline result is a set of nulls, with clear bunching at one kink only and only among the self-employed. Chetty et al. (2011) showed that optimization frictions attenuate bunching and that kinks affecting larger groups produce larger observed responses. Kleven and Waseem (2013) extended the method to notches and showed that large shares of agents remain in dominated regions, which identifies frictions. Kleven (2016) states the caveat that governs this paper: absence of bunching implies either a low structural elasticity or high frictions, and the data around the threshold cannot separate them. Bertanha, McCallum, and Seegert (2023) provide inference for the partially identified case, which is the frame for the bounds reported here.

Thresholds in sport have produced some of the clearest bunching evidence outside tax data. Pope and Simonsohn (2011) show that batters entering a season’s final at-bat at .298 or .299 hit .463 in it, and Allen et al. (2017) find marathon times piling up just under round numbers. Both settings share features the 65-game rule lacks: the threshold sits near the center of the outcome distribution and the marginal action is cheap and available to everyone near the line. A games threshold sits in the upper tail of a distribution shaped mostly by injury, and the marginal action is unavailable to an injured player.

Awards and tournaments as incentives

The rule conditions access to a rank-order tournament. Lazear and Rosen (1981) showed that effort responds to the spread between prizes, and Ehrenberg and Bognanno (1990) confirmed it on the golf tour. Awards without money attached also move behavior: Kosfeld and Neckermann (2011) found that symbolic awards raised performance in a field experiment, Neckermann, Cueni, and Frey (2014) found the same for workplace awards, and Chan et al. (2014) for academic honors; Frey and Gallus (2017) treat awards as a distinct instrument. These results justify treating All-NBA selection as an incentive even where no bonus is written into a contract, and they make the null more informative: the prize is one people respond to.

Strategic responses in sports labor markets

Kahn (2000) made the case for sports data as a labor-market laboratory. NBA players respond to individual financial incentives at some margins and not others: Stiroh (2007) found performance rising before a new contract and falling after, and Owsik and Tan (2026) find no regular-season contract-year effect but a decline after signing. Teams respond to bright-line league rules: Taylor and Trogon (2002) and Price et al. (2010) show teams losing more often when the draft rewards losing, Fumarco et al. (2024) document responses to contractual thresholds in hockey, and a 2024 case in which a baseball player was released four plate appearances short of a bonus is the mirror image of the individual incentive studied here (CBS Sports 2024). The 65-game rule differs from these settings in that the threshold applies to a named class of players and interacts with an injury process the player does not control.

Why star availability matters, and what drives it

Rosen (1981) explained why a few performers capture a disproportionate share of a market’s value. Hausman and Leonard (1997) put the value of one star to the other teams in the league at about 53 million dollars, and Kaplan (2022) found that a superstar’s announced absence lowers secondary-market ticket prices by 4 to 22 percent, more for road games; Kaplan et al. (2019) is the conference precursor. That externality is what the PPP is designed to internalize. On the supply side, Teramoto et al. (2017) tied game injuries to back-to-back and road games, with the caution of Mack et al. (2018) that exposures are not risks; Esteves et al. (2021) show that schedule congestion degrades performance; and Torres-Ronda et al. (2022) count more than 800 injuries per season, concentrated in the middle and late season. League figures for 2024-25 reported games missed to injury up 13 percent and stars missing 19 percent of games to injury in each post-rule season, the same as in 2017-18 and 2018-19 (Sportico 2025). These are press figures, but they set the scale: injury absence is an order of magnitude larger than anything a rest policy could reach.

Competing work

A search of SSRN, NBER, arXiv, the MIT Sloan Sports Analytics Conference, and Google Scholar returned no article, working paper, or thesis that evaluates the 65-game rule or the PPP as its research question. The nearest item is Nakamura-Sakai, Forastiere, and Macdonald (2024). The league’s own claims about the rule’s effect are descriptive (Sportico 2024). Section 5.2 shows what the raw comparison consists of.

3 A simple model

“I guess use your 17 games as wisely as possible.” Bam Adebayo, January 2024, on the 65-game rule (Hoops Rumors 2024a).

Consider a star deciding, game by game, whether to play. Let q be the number of qualifying games so far, r the number of games remaining, and $\bar{q} = 65$ the threshold. Each game played yields a flow benefit b and carries a cost c_g that varies with fatigue, minor injury, and schedule. Eligibility is worth $V \geq 0$ and is received if and only if $q \geq \bar{q}$ at season’s end. Before the rule V enters continuously through voters’ impressions; after it, as a step.

Three predictions follow. A player who reaches exactly 65 has no further eligibility motive to play, so mass should collect at the threshold and thin just above it. Define slack as $q + r - \bar{q}$, the number of remaining games a player can miss and still reach the line. For players with small non-negative slack late in the season, the option value of eligibility raises the return to playing through a marginal cost, so the share reaching 65 should rise after the rule, most among players for whom V is largest. Once slack is negative or $q \geq \bar{q}$, the marginal eligibility incentive is zero, so absence in those states should rise relative to the reachable state.

A fourth prediction concerns minutes. Because a game counts only at 20 minutes, a player or coach who wants a game to count will not let an appearance end at 18 minutes. After the rule, the share of star appearances lasting at least 20 minutes should rise, and rise most for players near the line. This margin is cheap in a way that games are not: it requires no additional appearance, only that an appearance already being made be long enough to count.

The magnitude of every prediction scales with V and with the number of players for whom the threshold is pivotal. A player who would have played 75 games regardless is unaffected; so is a player whose injury ends the season at 40. Section 7 counts the pivotal population and bounds the aggregate effect. The PPP pushes against the third prediction: its fines apply in every state, so it predicts a uniform fall in discretionary absence.

4 Data

Sources and definitions

Player-game box scores come from ESPN through hoopR (Gilani 2021), for regular seasons 2013-14 through 2025-26; seasons are indexed by end year. The 2019-20 and 2020-21 seasons are excluded from every estimate. Honors come from Basketball-Reference pages cached once, with the 2025 and 2026 All-Star rosters entered by hand. Estimation uses `fixest` (Bergé 2018).

A star in season s is a player who made an All-Star or All-NBA team in any of seasons $s - 3$ to $s - 1$, the PPP’s definition; because it is lagged it cannot respond to the treatment. There are 36 to 46 stars per season with at least one appearance `[tab1_sample]`. A contender is a star who made an All-NBA team or received an MVP or Defensive Player of the Year vote in the prior season. The control group is defined the same way, on prior-season status: players who are not stars in season s and who in season $s - 1$ averaged at least 28 minutes per game and played at least 40 games. They number 68 to 90 per season from 2015 on; none can be defined for 2014. A robustness control uses rotation players, 20 or more minutes and 40 or more games in the prior season. Defining the control on the prior season matters. An earlier version of this analysis defined it on current-season

minutes and games, which selects on the outcome: a control player could not have missed more than 42 games while a star could have missed 80, and the accompanying filter on rostered games truncated the stars’ low tail. That design is retained as a labeled comparison row. Both controls are partially treated, since All-Defensive, Most Improved, and Sixth Man awards carry the same requirement.

Qualifying games follow the rule’s definition and include the tournament final; games played is the regular-season statistic and excludes it. Slack, eligibility state, and the health condition are defined at the player-game level as in Section 3. The late-season window is team game 56 onward. A player is *healthy* entering a game if he played his team’s previous game.

What ESPN box scores contain

An ESPN box score carries the players on a team’s active list for that game: those who played, and those who dressed and did not play, who appear as a row with a reason string. Players on the inactive list, whether injured, ill, away from the team, or resting, do not appear at all. I verified this against seven Basketball-Reference box scores spanning 2015 to 2026, chosen so that a star had an absence with no ESPN row. All 40 ESPN did-not-play rows in those games appear inside the Basketball-Reference box as did-not-play or did-not-dress; none of the 51 players Basketball-Reference lists as inactive has an ESPN row; and all seven stars are on the inactive list [tabA14_bbr_boxscore_check].

The distinction matters because the two absence types have moved in opposite directions. Table 2 [tab2_source_coverage] reports the share of absences that appear as a dressed-but-unused row. For stars it was 28 to 40 percent in 2014 through 2017, 15 percent in 2018 and 2019, 7 to 10 percent in 2022 through 2024, and 8 to 16 percent after. For the control it fell from 30 to 38 percent in 2015-2017 to between 9 and 23 percent from 2022 on. The total absence rate of stars did not fall; it was between 14 and 32 percent of team-games in every season. Teams moved absent players from the bench to the inactive list. Any outcome computed from box-score rows therefore tracks roster designation, not behavior, and neither designation maps to rest versus injury. I build the player-game panel on the full schedule of each player’s team stints, with a flag for whether a row exists.¹

Two smaller corrections. ESPN files the All-Star and Rising Stars games as regular-season games; removing those rows lowers qualifying games by one for ten to seventeen stars per season through 2024, and three star-seasons cross 65 only because of them [tabA7_exhibition_correction]. And 14 flagged star-seasons outside the pandemic years have no appearance, mostly retired players still flagged from earlier honors [tabA6_stars_no_appearance]. A check of ten star-seasons against Basketball-Reference finds all nine with a reference value matching exactly; the tenth played no games [tabA5_bbr_validation].

¹The exploratory construction that counted only games with a row produced star “rest” rates of 7.1 percent in 2014 and 1.1 percent in 2023 [rest_raw_by_season_rowonly.csv], a fall that coincides with the fall in row coverage in Table 2. Those replications are in Appendix Table A1.

The same source property limits what can be learned about rest. Among late-season absences by stars who had played the previous game, 45 percent had a dressed-but-unused row before the rule and 19 percent after. Of the reasons given, rest and coach’s decision account for a quarter of all such absences before the rule and 2.6 percent after; the remainder are injury strings or inactive-list absences with no reason [tabA4_absence_reasons; rest_absence_reason_bounds.csv]. Discretionary rest and new injury cannot be separated in this source.

The sample

Table 1 [tab1_sample] describes the sample. Stars averaged 59.4 games in 2023 and 65.0 in 2024; the share with at least 65 qualifying games went from 0.44 to 0.67. Both fell back in 2025 and 2026, to 62.4 and 54.8 games and to 0.54 and 0.47. The control averaged 65.6 games in 2023, 66.1 in 2024, 62.0 in 2025, and 58.8 in 2026.

5 Availability results

Event studies

Figure 3 and Table 3a [tab3a_availability_event_study] report event-study estimates of star availability relative to the control, with 2023 as the reference season, from a regression of games played or qualifying games on star-by-season indicators with player and season fixed effects, on all star and control player-seasons from 2015 to 2026 with no filter on the outcome. Standard errors are clustered by player throughout, following Bertrand, Duflo, and Mullainathan (2004). Every null is accompanied by its minimum detectable effect, defined once here as the effect detected with 80 percent power in a two-sided 5 percent test given the estimated standard error, 2.80 times that standard error. The sample is 1,093 player-seasons of 255 players [tab3b_availability_pooled].

The post-rule coefficients for games played are -0.41 (SE 2.95) in 2024, -0.20 (3.00) in 2025, and -2.87 (4.48) in 2026, with minimum detectable effects of 8.3, 8.4, and 12.6 games. Pre-period coefficients lie between -5.30 and 3.28 and none is distinguishable from zero. Qualifying games give 2.04 (3.15), 2.00 (3.11), and -0.12 (4.59). Pooling the post-rule seasons [tab3b_availability_pooled], the star-specific change in games played is -0.81 (2.32), with a 95 percent interval from -5.37 to 3.75 games and a minimum detectable effect of 6.5. For qualifying games it is 1.72 (2.45) with an upper limit of 6.52. The share at or above 65 rises by 0.067 (0.070), minimum detectable effect 0.20. The blue band in Figure 3 shows the pooled interval so that the reader sees one bound rather than eleven wide whiskers.

The rotation control gives 2.47 (2.14) for games played but 6.81 (2.30) for qualifying games, with a 2017 coefficient of 5.10 (2.27). I do not read the qualifying-games result as a rule effect. A rotation player’s qualifying count sits on the 20-minute margin: the group’s ratio of qualifying games to games played is 0.64 to 0.73 across seasons against 0.97 to 0.99 for stars [qg_gp_ratio_by_group.csv], so for that group the outcome measures minutes, and Section 7.3 treats the minutes margin directly. The exploratory design, with the current-season control and

the rostered-games filter, gives 1.05 (1.41) pooled; its narrower interval comes from truncating the stars' low tail.

What happened in 2024

Table A8 [tabA8_composition_2024] decomposes the 5.6-game rise in mean star games from 2023 to 2024, against a control change of 0.6. The 39 players who were stars in both seasons went from 61.3 to 64.2, a rise of 2.9. The seven entrants averaged 69.6 games; the six leavers had averaged 46.7 in 2023. Half of the raw rise is composition and half is a within-player rise. Among control stayers, games played fell by 3.8.

Table A9 [tabA9_cohort_pairs] estimates a fixed-cohort difference-in-differences for every pair of adjacent seasons, with groups fixed at their status in the first season and players present in both. The 2023-to-2024 estimate is 4.66 (SE 3.44, $p = 0.18$). The five pre-rule pairs range from -3.59 to 4.15; 2024-to-2025 gives 3.91 and 2025-to-2026 gives -5.16. The rule's first season produced the largest adjacent-season swing in the series, by half a game, and the swing reversed in the next two seasons. The multi-season event study puts 2024 at -0.41 (2.95).

Bunching at 65

Figure 2 plots the distribution of qualifying games for star player-seasons before and after the rule, with the pre-rule distribution overlaid on the post-rule panel as the counterfactual, following Saez (2010) and Kleven and Waseem (2013). Table 4a [tab4a_bunching_bins] gives the mass in four bins: 0.122 of pre-rule star-seasons and 0.114 of post-rule star-seasons in the bin just below the threshold, 58 to 64 games; 0.125 and 0.106 just above, 65 to 68.

Table 4b [tab4b_bunching_excess_mass] reports an excess-mass estimator with the pre-rule distribution of 327 star-seasons scaled to the 132 post-rule star-seasons as the counterfactual, b the excess count in a window above 65 divided by the mean counterfactual mass per one-game bin in that window, m the analogous statistic below, and intervals from 2,000 bootstrap resamples. At exactly 65 games there are 7 post-rule star-seasons against a counterfactual of 3.6, for $b = 0.93$ with a 95 percent interval from -0.38 to 4.57. Widening to 65 and 66 gives 7 against 8.9, $b = -0.42$ [-1.45, 1.30]; widening to 65 through 68 gives 14 against 16.6, $b = -0.62$ [-2.24, 1.81]. No window rejects zero. With only 2022 and 2023 as the counterfactual the estimates turn negative, $b = -2.22$ [-3.11, -0.76] for the widest window, because those two seasons placed unusual mass just above 65.

The seven post-rule seasons at exactly 65 deserve a closer look, and Section 5.4 gives it to them.

At-risk stars and the case table

At team game 62, with twenty games remaining, a star with slack between 0 and 8 can still reach 65 but cannot miss many more games. Table 5a [tab5a_at_risk_reach] reports, for stars also healthy at game 62, whether they finished with 65. Post-rule there are 2 such stars with slack 0 to 2, 8 with slack 3 to 5, and 11 with slack 6 to 8, with reach rates of 1.00, 0.62, and 0.64 against pre-rule rates

of 0.40, 0.70, and 0.60 from 20, 27, and 25 star-seasons; Fisher exact p-values are 0.19, 0.69, and 1.00. A linear probability model pooling the bins [tab5b_at_risk_regressions] gives a post-rule change of 0.06 (SE 0.13) among healthy at-risk stars, minimum detectable effect 0.35, from 21 post-rule observations. These tests cannot detect a change in the reach probability smaller than about a third.

Table 5d [tab5d_case_table] lists every one of those 21 post-rule star-seasons: slack at game 62, whether the player reached 65, the minutes of his first four appearances after his last absence before game 62, and the stakes attached to eligibility where I could establish them. The table is the population the rule was written for, and it is small enough to read. Three patterns stand out. First, the return-minutes column contains the managed re-entry the rule predicts: after his last pre-62 absence in 2024, one player returned for four games of 22, 22, 22, and 20 minutes, each one qualifying game more than an 18-minute appearance would have been, and a second player in 2026 returned at 21, 26, 26, and 27. Most returners went straight back to 30-plus minutes. Second, the stakes column, sourced from contract reporting and marked for verification against Spotrac, shows why: the two players with managed returns had a Rose Rule escalator or qualification riding on All-NBA selection, while most of those who fell short had no award-linked contract term. Third, of the seven post-rule star-seasons at exactly 65, three belong to healthy at-risk stars with slack of 1, 2, and 3 at game 62, who landed on the line and stopped.

That third pattern is the notch’s individual-level fingerprint, and Table A11 [tabA11_exact65] puts a number on it. Among at-risk stars who reached 65, 8 of 46 finished at exactly 65 before the rule and 6 of 18 after, 17 against 33 percent, Fisher $p = 0.19$. Among healthy at-risk reachers the shares are 19 and 36 percent, $p = 0.27$. Before the rule, at-risk reachers spread across 65 to 72, with 66 the modal finish; after it, six of eighteen sit on 65 and none on 66 [tabA11b_exact65_distribution]. Across all star reachers the share at exactly 65 is 5 percent before and 9 percent after, $p = 0.16$. The pattern is what “secure and sit” produces, on the only population where it could appear, and it is a handful of players.

6 Absence behavior

What is measured

The outcome in this section is absence: a player did not play a late-season game after having played his team’s previous game. On the full schedule this rate runs between 7.9 and 13.2 percent of star player-games across seasons [rest_raw_by_season.csv]. It includes players injured in the game they had just played and players who chose to sit, and the source cannot separate them. Nothing here should be read as a rest rate. The design can detect changes of four to seven percentage points in this rate; changes in discretionary rest smaller than that, or offset by opposite changes in injury absence, are not visible.

Absence by eligibility state

Table 6a [tab6a_absence_by_state] and Figure 4 report absence by eligibility state. Before the rule, healthy late-season stars were absent from 7.1 percent of games in the reachable state, 10.8 percent when eligibility was secured, and 14.6 percent when 65 was out of reach. After the rule the rates are 9.1, 12.4, and 16.1 percent. The reachable-state rise of 2.0 points (SE 0.9) is the one change distinguishable from zero, and it is in the state where the notch predicts a fall. The secured and unreachable states, where the notch predicts a rise, changed by 1.5 (1.5) and 1.4 (2.0). The gradient across states is present in both periods and is what an injury process produces without any incentive: players who have missed enough games to fall out of reach are players who are hurt.

Table 6b [tab6b_absence_state_regressions] puts the secured-versus-reachable comparison in a regression with player-season and team-game-number fixed effects, so that the interaction is identified from players who move between states within a late season. The secured-by-post coefficient is -0.011 (SE 0.019), with a minimum detectable effect of 0.053; the collapsed no-incentive interaction is -0.005 (0.019). The unreachable state is omitted from the regression: within a player-season its games follow a long absence, so the within-player contrast is mechanically negative, and the post interaction is identified from too few transitions to be informative; Table 6a carries that state. The design can detect a post-rule rise in secured-state absence of about five percentage points, half the pre-rule rate, and finds none.

Stars against the control at two policy breaks

Table 6c [tab6c_absence_star_vs_nonstar] and Figure 5 compare stars with the control. The post-rule coefficients relative to 2023 are -0.008 (SE 0.018) in 2024, -0.017 (0.025) in 2025, and -0.018 (0.024) in 2026, with minimum detectable effects of 0.050, 0.069, and 0.068 [tabA1_absence_event_study]; no pre-period coefficient exceeds 0.035. The pooled post-rule-by-star coefficient is -0.019 (0.016) across 2014 to 2026 and -0.023 (0.015) across 2022 to 2026, minimum detectable effects 0.044 and 0.043. For the September 2017 resting policy, the post-2017-by-star coefficient over 2014 to 2019 is 0.010 (0.016). Neither policy produced a detectable star-specific change in late-season absence.²

7 Mechanisms

The notch binds on few

Table 5c [tab5c_bound] and Appendix Figure A1 count, in each season, the stars with slack between 0 and 8 at team game 62. There are between 5 and 18 such stars per season, an average of 10.2

²Broadcast strings are empty in the source before 2022, so the PPP's national-television provision can be tested only against 2022 and 2023, and both regimes protected televised games. Over that window, absence by healthy late-season stars in non-televised games went from 12.4 to 13.5 percent and in televised games from 11.2 to 7.2 percent [rest_tv_rates.csv]; the triple difference with player-season and game-number fixed effects is -0.023 (0.021) [rest_tv_ddd.csv]. The test cannot distinguish the PPP from the 2017 policy and I do not use it.

before the rule and 11.3 after, a quarter of all stars. Of those, 4.5 per season before the rule and 5.3 after finished short of 65. Two bounds follow. Under minimal crossing, every at-risk star who fell short instead reaches exactly 65; summing those games and dividing by the number of stars gives 0.67 games per star-season in the pre-rule seasons and 0.96 in the post-rule seasons. If every at-risk star plays every remaining game, the bound is 1.27 games pre-rule and 1.85 post-rule. The upper limit of the pooled qualifying-games interval is 6.52 games.

The window is a choice, and Table A10 [tabA10_bound_windows] varies it. Widening the window to slack 0 to 12 at game 62 raises the pre-rule at-risk count to 17.9 per season and the bounds to 0.75 and 2.05. Measuring slack at game 55 with the 0-to-8 window gives 9.5 at risk and bounds of 0.89 and 1.55; at game 55 with the 0-to-12 window, 16.8 at risk, 41 percent of stars, and bounds of 1.07 and 2.42. Post-rule the widest construction reaches 3.79 under full play-through. The concern that motivates the wider windows is the star with ten games of slack who, absent the rule, would have been shut down on an eliminated team. Such seasons exist: among the 19 stars per season with slack of 9 or more at game 62, one per season finished below 65 before the rule, adding 0.10 games per star-season to the bound [at_risk_slack9plus_summary.csv]. Every construction leaves the bound inside the estimated interval. The claim survives, restated: the rule binds on a quarter to two-fifths of stars, and even a full response from all of them would move the mean by one to two games, below what a season-level comparison can detect.

Star absences are spells, and spells rose for everyone

Appendix Table A3 [tabA3_long_absences] describes spells of ten or more consecutive missed games. Before the rule there were 127 star spells in 327 star-seasons, 0.39 per star-season, and 33 percent of star-seasons contained one; after the rule, 65 in 132, 0.49 per star-season, 39 percent. Long spells account for 10.0 missed games per star-season before the rule and 11.0 after. Spells that begin with a rest or coach’s-decision string are 11 percent before the rule and none after; the majority have no row at any point.

The rise is not specific to stars. The control went from 0.39 to 0.46 spells per player-season, 18 percent against the stars’ 27, and from 34 to 38 percent of player-seasons with a spell against the stars’ 33 to 39. By season, star spells per star-season were 0.58 in 2023, 0.33 in 2024, 0.43 in 2025, and 0.75 in 2026; the control’s were 0.35, 0.38, 0.48, and 0.56 [absences_by_season.csv]. The rise is concentrated in 2025 and 2026 for both groups and coincides with the league-wide increase in injuries reported for 2024-25 (Sportico 2025).

One difference remains. The share of star spells beginning in the late-season window rose from 27 of 127 to 20 of 65, 21 to 31 percent, Fisher $p = 0.16$, while the control’s fell from 69 of 213 to 29 of 111, 32 to 26 percent, $p = 0.25$ (Table A13 [tabA13_late_onset]; Figure A2). The difference in shares, stars minus control and post minus pre, is 0.158 with a bootstrap 95 percent interval from -0.012 to 0.329. It is the one number in the paper that points toward the union’s claim that players are playing hurt to reach the line, and Section 8.2 says what can and cannot be made of it.

The detectable effect: minutes

Section 3’s fourth prediction is that the rule should lengthen short appearances, because an appearance under 20 minutes does not count. Table A12 [tabA12_share20_event_study] tests it on every appearance by stars and the control, with player, season, and team-game-number fixed effects. The share of star appearances lasting at least 20 minutes was 0.976 in 2023 and 0.985, 0.984, and 0.981 in the three post-rule seasons; the control’s was 0.908 in 2023 and 0.903, 0.922, and 0.912 after. The star-by-season coefficients relative to 2023 are 0.043 (SE 0.016), 0.040 (0.013), and 0.055 (0.016), each significant at the 1 percent level, against pre-period coefficients no larger than 0.025 in absolute value with no p-value below 0.30. Pooled, the post-rule change is 0.046 (0.010), minimum detectable effect 0.029; in the late-season window it is 0.070 (0.016). The control did not move, so the change is not a league-wide shift in rotations.

This is the rule’s one detectable effect, and it is the mechanism behind the managed returns in Table 5d. It is small in games: 4.6 percent of about 63 appearances is three appearances per star-season that now count and would not have. It is also consistent with the null on games. The rule did not change how often stars appear; it changed how long a marginal appearance lasts. The earlier version of this test, which compared minute bins for stars with 0 to 3 games of slack against other stars, shows nothing once players returning from injury are removed [tabA2_minute_bins], and I no longer report it as evidence.

8 Discussion

What the results show

Across every test the notch model suggests on games, the rule left no detectable mark. There is no excess mass at 65. The stars nearest the line were no more likely to cross it. Star availability moved with the control, and the one season in which it appeared to move away was half composition and half a swing of a size the series had produced before and reversed after. Absence among stars who had just played did not rise in the states where the rule removed the incentive; it rose by two points in the state where the incentive remained. The reason is that the rule can matter only to the quarter to two-fifths of stars within reach of the line in the season’s final weeks, and a complete response by all of them would add one to two games to the mean. The rest of star absence is injury, and injury is indifferent to award eligibility. This is the frictions reading of a null in Kleven (2016): not a zero elasticity, but a threshold placed where few agents can respond, and where the cheap margin of response is minutes rather than games. On that margin the rule shows: stars now almost never appear for fewer than 20 minutes.

What the results do not show

The design bounds effects; it does not estimate them precisely. A star-specific gain of one to three games per season is inside every interval and is the size the bounding argument allows. The exactly-

65 pattern in Table A11 is what a few players securing eligibility and stopping would produce, and a reader who believes the rule changed a handful of seasons at the margin will find nothing here that contradicts them.

The design cannot test the hypothesis that the rule causes injury by inducing players to play hurt. Table A13 contains a number that moves that way: a 16-point shift in the late-onset share of star spells relative to the control, with an interval that reaches from -0.01 to 0.33. Three things stand between that number and a test. It rests on 20 post-rule spells. The rise in spells was league-wide, with 2025 and 2026 heavy injury seasons for both groups, so any star-specific timing shift sits on top of a common shock that three post-rule seasons cannot net out. And the source records no diagnosis, severity, or pre-injury workload, so a spell beginning at game 60 cannot be classified as an aggravation carried through games 50 to 59 or a new event. A test would need injury reports with diagnosis and severity, a measure of workload before onset, and a comparison of onset hazards between at-risk stars and stars far from the line at the same point in the season, over enough seasons for the injury cycle to average out. I report the number so that it is not left unaddressed, and I do not claim to have tested it.

The absence results rest on an outcome the source cannot decompose. A change in discretionary rest smaller than four to seven points would not be detected, and a change offset by injury absence would not be visible. Both control groups are partially treated; if All-Defensive, Most Improved, and Sixth Man candidates responded, the estimates are biased toward zero, though the bounding argument does not depend on a control group. Three post-rule seasons is a short window. The waivers granted in 2026 mean the notch is administered with discretion at the margin, which weakens the incentive for the players nearest the line in a way the model does not capture, and the stakes may grow as more contracts write bonuses against All-NBA selection.

Implications

For the league, award eligibility is the wrong lever for the availability problem as it exists. The players whose absences drive the aggregate are injured, and the players who are healthy and choosing are few and already playing most nights. A rule that binds on ten to eighteen players a season, each of whom can add a few games, has a ceiling of one to two games per star, below the noise in a season's schedule. What the rule does reliably is lengthen short appearances, which is not what it was for.

For the study of notches, the case is a useful negative with a positive attached. The bunching literature grew around settings where the population near the threshold is large relative to the whole. Here the notch is clean, the prize is real and of a kind people respond to (Kosfeld and Neckermann 2011; Frey and Gallus 2017), and the population at the margin is small, so the absence of bunching is evidence that the estimator has nothing to work with rather than that the elasticity is zero. Reporting the size of the at-risk population and the bound it implies alongside the null, in the partially identified spirit of Bertanha, McCallum, and Seegert (2023), is the appropriate presentation, and looking for the response on the cheapest adjacent margin is where it turned up.

For researchers using ESPN box scores through hoopR or similar tools, Section 4.2 is the practical result. The source carries the active list. Absence, rest, and availability must be measured on the schedule.

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Tables and figures

Main text: Table 1 `tab1_sample`; Table 2 `tab2_source_coverage`; Table 3 `tab3a_availability_event_study`, `tab3b_availability_pooled`; Table 4 `tab4a_bunching_bins`, `tab4b_bunching_excess_mass`; Table 5 `tab5a_at_risk_reach`, `tab5b_at_risk_regressions`, `tab5c_bound`, `tab5d_case_table`; Table 6 `tab6a_absence_by_state`, `tab6b_absence_state_regressions`, `tab6c_absence_star_vs_nonstar`. Figures: 1 `fig1_policy_timeline`; 2 `fig2_bunching_histogram`; 3 `fig3_availability_event_study`; 4 `fig4_absence_by_state`; 5 `fig5_absence_stars_vs_nonstars`.

Appendix: Tables A1-A14 (`tabA1_absence_event_study`, `tabA2_minute_bins`, `tabA3_long_absences`, `tabA4_absence_reasons`, `tabA5_bbr_validation`, `tabA6_stars_no_appearance`, `tabA7_exhibition_correction`, `tabA8_composition_2024`, `tabA9_cohort_pairs`, `tabA10_bound_windows`, `tabA11_exact65`, `tabA11b_exact65_distribution`, `tabA12_share20_event_study`, `tabA13_late_onset`, `tabA14_bbr_boxscore_check`); Figures A1-A3 (`figA1_at_risk_by_season`, `figA2_absence_timing`, `figA3_absence_by_state_by_season`).

Changes from v2

1. Section 4.2 rewritten around the active and inactive lists, with the Basketball-Reference verification (Table A14, script 07).
2. The tournament final now counts toward qualifying games, as the league counts it; the Wembanyama 2026 case is explained in 2.1 and the bunching, at-risk, and validation tables are updated.
3. Table A10 and the slack-9-plus count added; 7.1 restated.
4. Table 5d integrated in 5.4; Table A11 (exactly 65) added.
5. Table A12 (20-minute share against the control) added; 7.3 rewritten around it; the minute-bin table demoted.
6. Table A13 (late-onset test with Fisher p-values and bootstrap interval) added; 7.2 and 8.2 updated.
7. Unreachable rows dropped from Table 6b and the main effect explained.
8. Abstract, JEL codes, keywords, and the timeline figure added; figures renumbered.
9. v3.1: Berri and Krautmann DOI corrected; November 2019 and December 2020 memos added to Section 2.1 and Figure 1; the five-of-fifteen All-NBA fact added to 2.1; Adembayo epigraph added to Section 3; Table 5d stakes column replaced with sourced entries (`assets/stakes_manual.csv`); LaTeX version built by `scripts/08_draft_to_tex.R`.
10. Intro shortened; national-TV test to a footnote; rows-only construction to a footnote; 2.4 shortened; star count reconciled to 36 to 46; references completed and corrected; singular voice throughout.

Figures

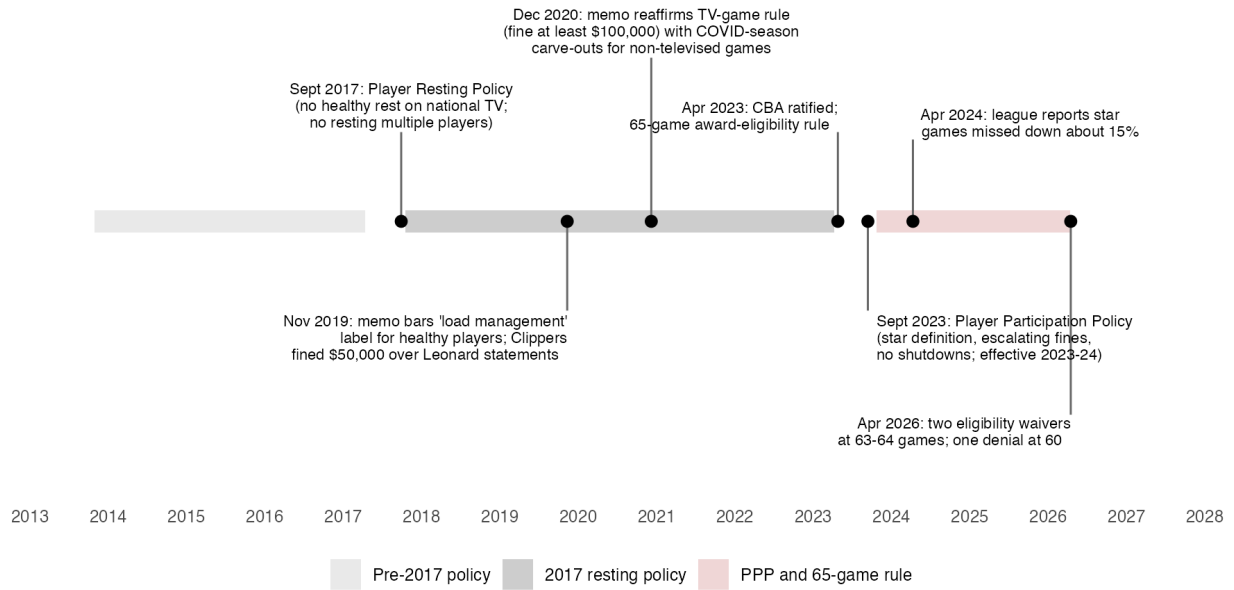


Figure 1: Policy timeline: the 2017 resting policy, the 2019 and 2020 memos, the 2023 CBA and Player Participation Policy, and the 2026 waivers. Shaded bars mark the regimes; 2019-20 and 2020-21 are excluded from estimation.

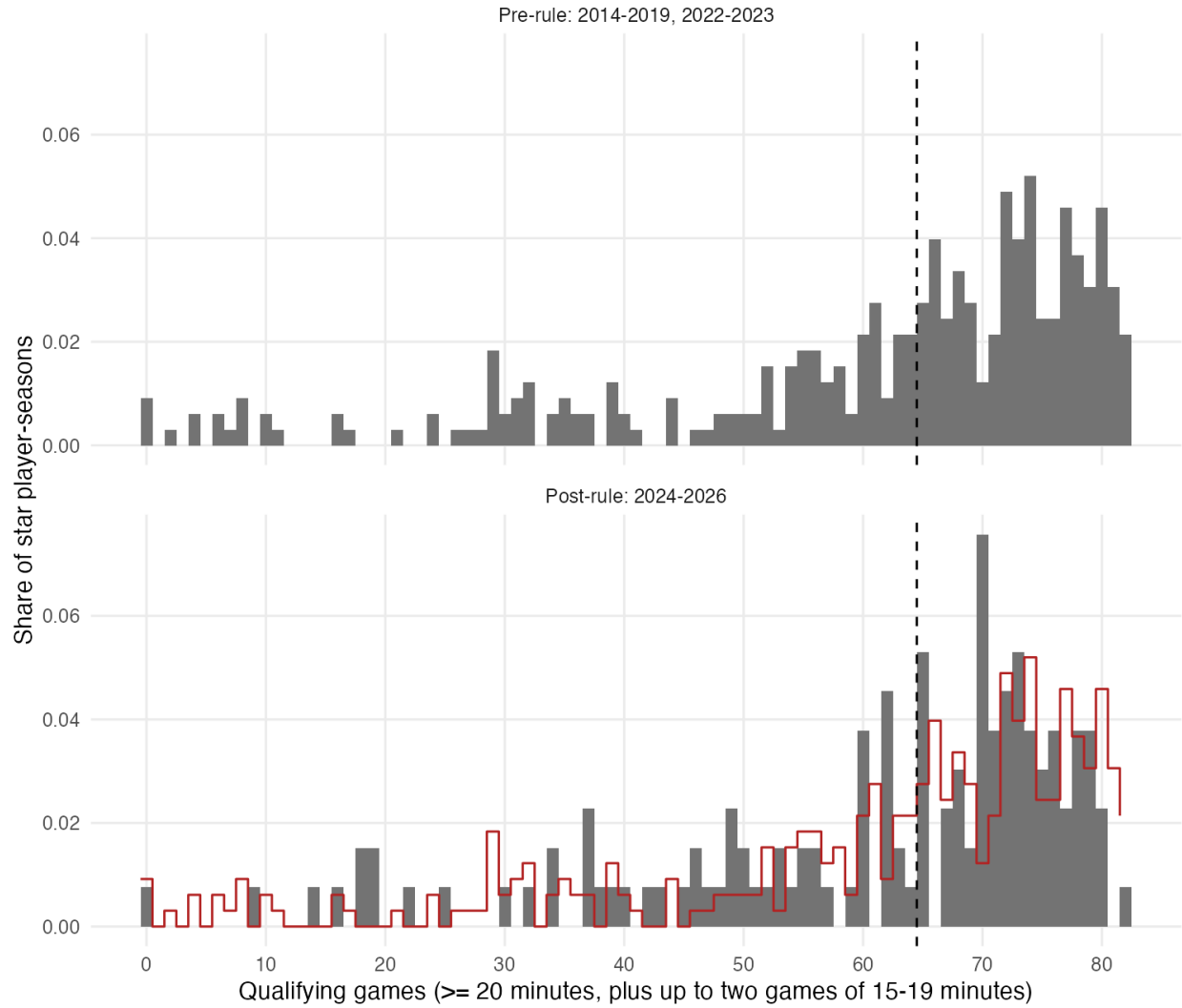


Figure 2: Qualifying games of star player-seasons before and after the 65-game rule. Dashed line: 65-game threshold. Red step in the lower panel: pre-rule distribution scaled to the post-rule count (the counterfactual).

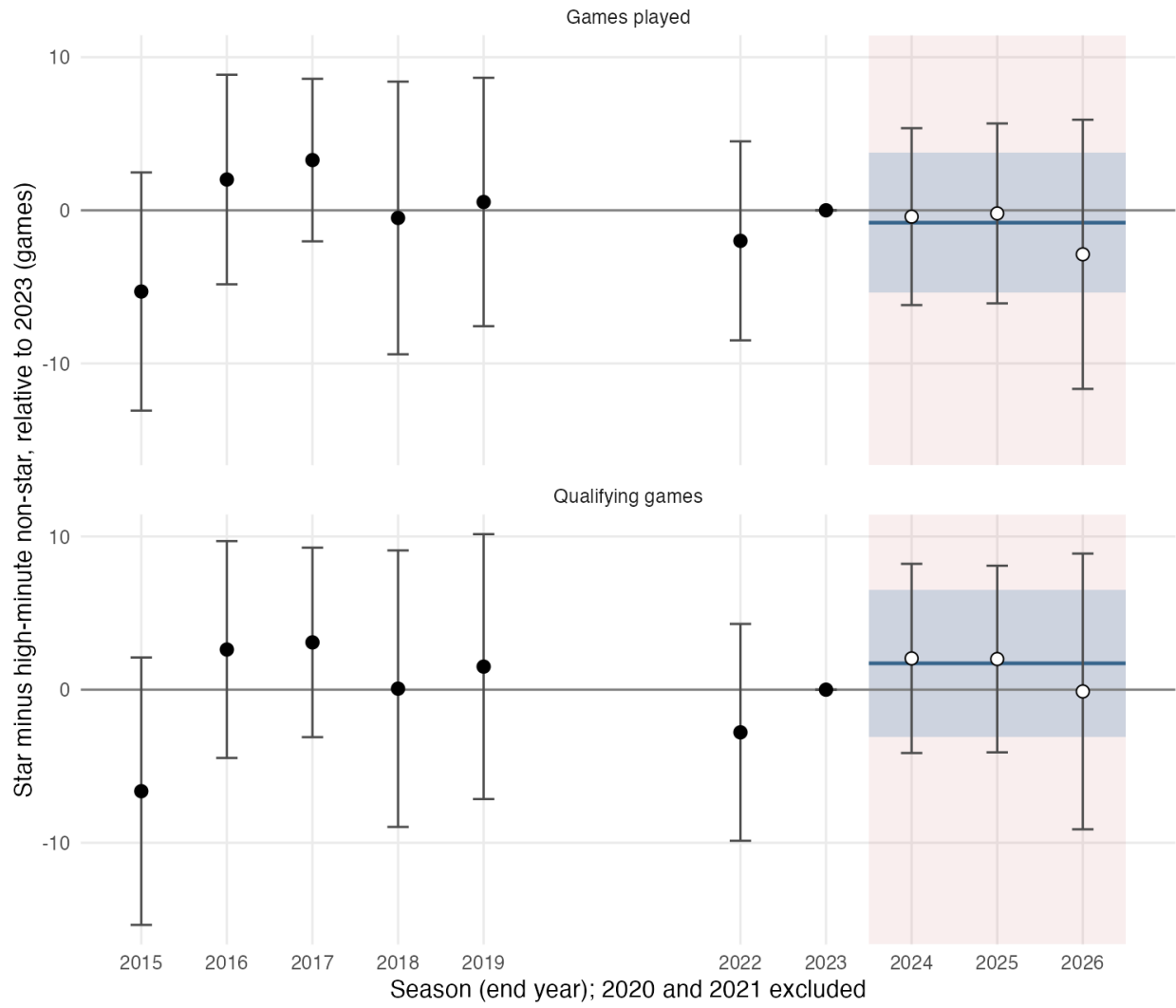


Figure 3: Star availability relative to high-minute non-stars defined on prior-season status, by season, reference 2023. Player and season fixed effects; 95 percent intervals clustered by player. Blue band: pooled post-rule estimate with its 95 percent interval.

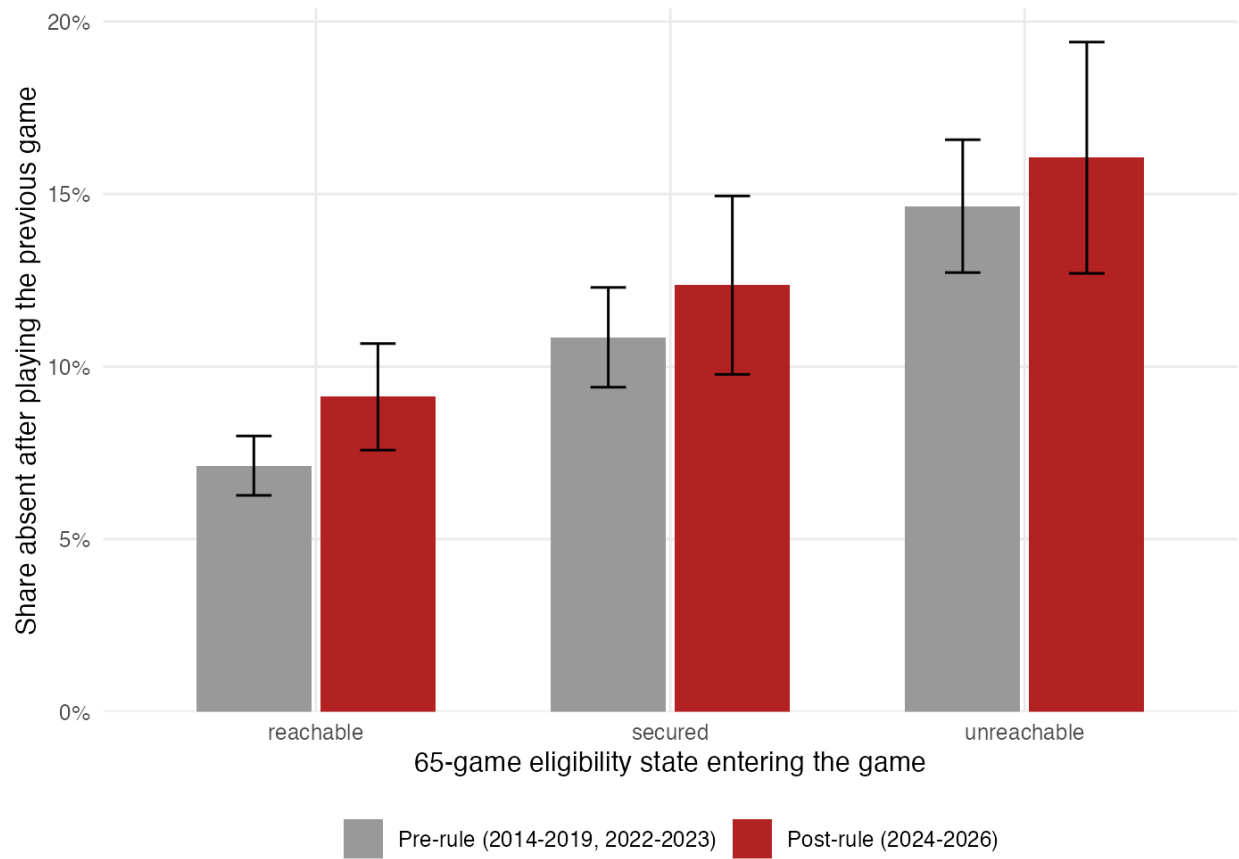


Figure 4: Late-season absence of stars who played the previous game, by eligibility state, before and after the rule, with 95 percent binomial intervals.

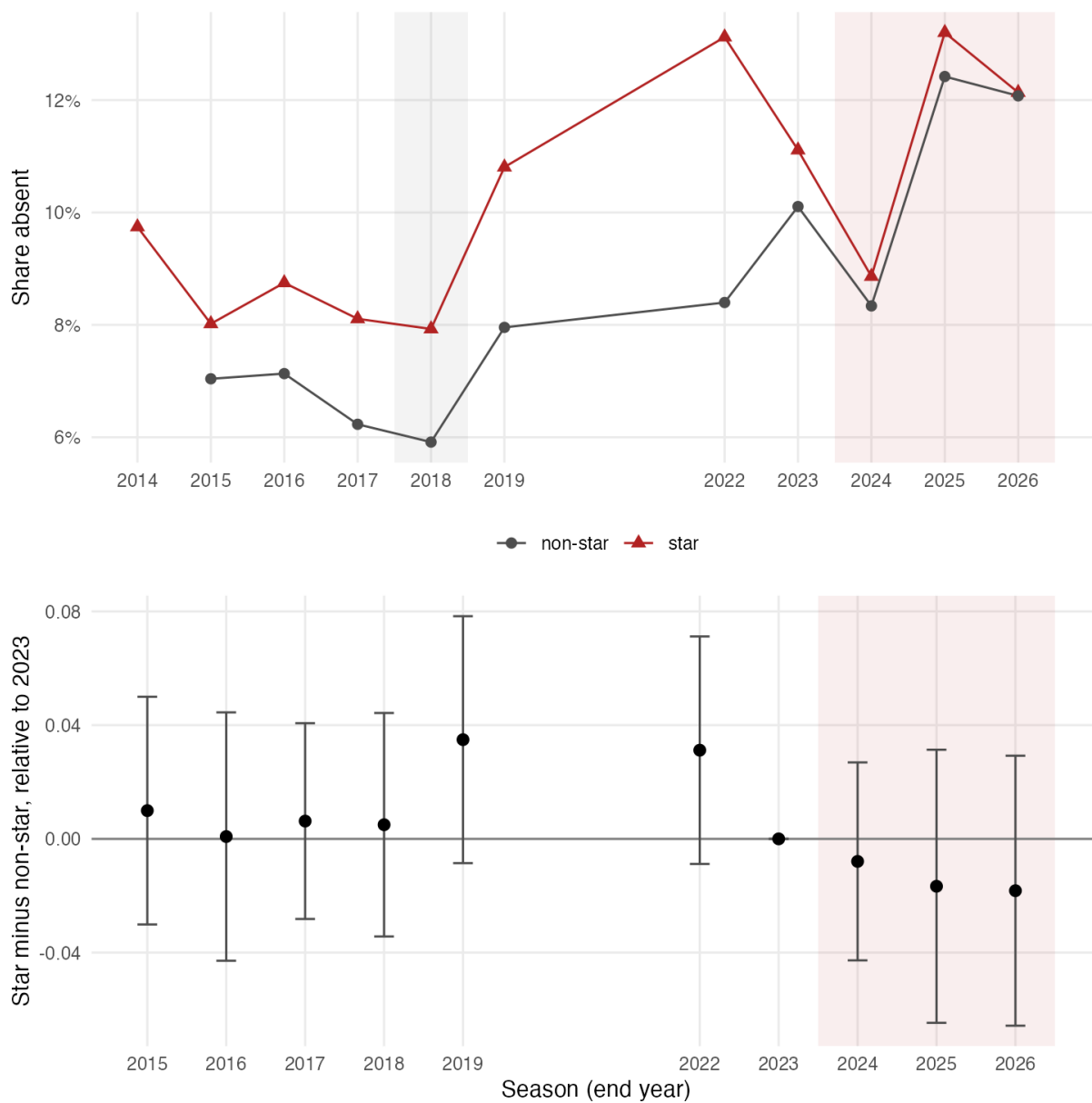


Figure 5: Late-season absence after playing the previous game: stars and the control group. Upper panel: raw rates. Lower panel: star-by-season coefficients relative to 2023 with player, season and game-number fixed effects.

Tables

Table 1: Sample by season: stars and the primary control group

Season	Period	Stars	No appearance	Games played	Qualifying games	Share ≥ 65	Contenders	High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Their games played
2014	Pre	41	0	60.3	57.9	0.49	21		0
2015	Pre	43	1	63.2	60.9	0.65	22	88	66.4
2016	Pre	46	0	69.1	66.0	0.70	17	71	66.9
2017	Pre	40	3	70.2	66.3	0.65	20	79	65.9
2018	Pre	36	3	64.2	62.2	0.58	16	74	63.3
2019	Pre	37	1	63.1	61.6	0.65	20	72	64.2
2022	Pre	39	4	58.1	56.7	0.54	18	76	60.9
2023	Pre	45	0	59.4	58.4	0.44	17	82	65.6
2024	Post	46	0	65.0	64.5	0.67	19	90	66.1
2025	Post	46	0	62.4	62.0	0.54	19	81	62.0
2026	Post	40	2	54.8	54.4	0.47	16	68	58.8

Note:

Seasons indexed by end year; 2020 and 2021 excluded. Stars: All-Star or All-NBA in any of the prior three seasons (the PPP definition), with at least one ESPN box-score appearance. 'No appearance': flagged stars with no row in the season (retired or absent all season). Games on regular-season schedule only; All-Star, Rising Stars and NBA Cup final rows removed. Qualifying games: ≥ 20 minutes plus up to two games of 15-19 minutes. Contenders: All-NBA or any MVP/DPOY vote in the prior season. High-minute non-stars: not a star in the season, and ≥ 28 minutes per game with ≥ 40 games played in the PRIOR season; none defined for 2014.

Table 2: ESPN box-score coverage of absences, by season

Season	Star team-games	Star absences	Star absence rate	Star absences with a DNP row	Non-star team-games	Non-star absences	Non-star absence rate	Non-star absences with a DNP row
2014	3331	860	25.8%	29%	NA	NA		
2015	3520	804	22.8%	28%	7211	1366	18.9%	30%
2016	3769	590	15.7%	37%	5826	1074	18.4%	38%
2017	3269	459	14.0%	40%	6444	1240	19.2%	35%
2018	2945	634	21.5%	15%	6033	1348	22.3%	17%
2019	3030	694	22.9%	15%	5860	1238	21.1%	16%
2022	3193	927	29.0%	10%	6217	1588	25.5%	9%
2023	3655	984	26.9%	7%	6710	1334	19.9%	17%
2024	3773	781	20.7%	8%	7311	1351	18.5%	19%
2025	3738	863	23.1%	16%	6603	1578	23.9%	23%
2026	3250	1053	32.4%	10%	5524	1520	27.5%	22%

Note:

Team-games: every regular-season game of the player's team stint(s). An absence is a team-game the player did not play. A DNP row is an ESPN box-score line for a player who did not play; it carries a reason string. Absences without a row carry no information beyond the fact of absence. Non-stars are high-minute non-stars by prior-season status.

Table 3: Star availability relative to high-minute non-stars, by season (reference 2023)

Season	GP: est (SE)	GP: MDE	QG: est (SE)	QG: MDE	GP, rotation control: est (SE)	GP, rotation: MDE
2015	-5.30 (3.97)	11.1	-6.63 (4.46)	12.5	-5.18 (3.91)	11.0
2016	2.01 (3.49)	9.8	2.62 (3.61)	10.1	2.20 (2.80)	7.8
2017	3.28 (2.71)	7.6	3.09 (3.16)	8.8	5.10 (2.27)	6.4
2018	-0.50 (4.54)	12.7	0.07 (4.61)	12.9	0.22 (3.82)	10.7
2019	0.54 (4.14)	11.6	1.51 (4.41)	12.4	0.76 (3.41)	9.5
2022	-1.99 (3.31)	9.3	-2.79 (3.61)	10.1	-0.31 (2.90)	8.1
2023	0.00 (0.00)	0.0	0.00 (0.00)	0.0	0.00 (0.00)	0.0
2024	-0.41 (2.95)	8.3	2.04 (3.15)	8.8	3.49 (2.72)	7.6
2025	-0.20 (3.00)	8.4	2.00 (3.11)	8.7	4.25 (2.71)	7.6
2026	-2.87 (4.48)	12.6	-0.12 (4.59)	12.9	-0.68 (4.01)	11.2

Note:

Outcomes: games played (GP) and qualifying games (QG) per player-season. Coefficients on star x season, player and season fixed effects, SEs clustered by player, 2020-2021 excluded, seasons 2015-2026, no filter on the outcome. Control groups are defined by prior-season status: high-minute (≥ 28 minutes per game, ≥ 40 games) or rotation (≥ 20 minutes, ≥ 40 games). MDE: minimum detectable effect at 80% power and 5% size (2.80 x SE), in games.

Table 4: Pooled post-rule x star differences in availability

Outcome	Control	Post x star: est (SE)	95% CI	MDE	Player-seasons	Players
Games played	High-minute non-stars (prior season)	-0.809 (2.325)	[-5.37, 3.75]	6.51	1093	255
Qualifying games	High-minute non-stars (prior season)	1.720 (2.449)	[-3.08, 6.52]	6.86	1093	255
Games played	Rotation non-stars (prior season)	2.468 (2.142)	[-1.73, 6.67]	6.00	2037	478
Qualifying games	Rotation non-stars (prior season)	6.814 (2.302)	[2.30, 11.33]	6.45	2037	478
Games played	Exploratory: contemporaneous control, ≥ 40 rostered games	1.048 (1.412)	[-1.72, 3.82]	3.96	1194	274
Qualifying games	Exploratory: contemporaneous control, ≥ 40 rostered games	0.942 (1.428)	[-1.86, 3.74]	4.00	1194	274
Share ≥ 65	High-minute non-stars (prior season)	0.067 (0.070)	[-0.07, 0.20]	0.20	1093	255

Note:

Post-rule = 2024-2026. Player and season fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. MDE at 80% power. The exploratory row conditions the control on games played ≥ 40 in the same season and drops player-seasons with fewer than 40 ESPN rows, which removes stars' long-injury seasons; it is shown for comparison only.

Table 5: Star player-seasons around the 65-game threshold, pre- vs post-rule

Qualifying games	Pre: n	Pre: share	Post: n	Post: share
<58	95	0.291	42	0.318
58-64 (below)	40	0.122	15	0.114
65-68 (just above)	41	0.125	14	0.106
69+	151	0.462	61	0.462

Note:

Stars, 2020-2021 excluded. Pre-rule 2014-2019 and 2022-2023; post-rule 2024-2026.

Table 6: Excess mass at and above 65 qualifying games, post-rule stars

Counterfactual	Window	Above: observed	Above: counterfactual	b (95% CI)	Below: observed	Below: counterfactual	m (95% CI)
All pre-rule seasons	65 vs 64	7	3.6	0.93 [-0.38, 4.57]	1	2.8	-0.65 [-1.00, 0.86]
All pre-rule seasons	65-66 vs 63-64	7	8.9	-0.42 [-1.45, 1.30]	3	5.7	-0.94 [-2.00, 1.05]
All pre-rule seasons	65-68 vs 58-64	14	16.6	-0.62 [-2.24, 1.81]	15	16.1	-0.50 [-3.53, 3.90]
2022-2023 only	65 vs 64	7	9.4	-0.26 [-0.76, 1.55]	1	3.1	-0.68 [-1.00, 0.91]
2022-2023 only	65-66 vs 63-64	7	18.9	-1.26 [-1.77, -0.18]	3	6.3	-1.05 [-2.00, 3.09]
2022-2023 only	65-68 vs 58-64	14	31.4	-2.22 [-3.11, -0.76]	15	15.7	-0.32 [-3.86, 9.04]

Note:

Counterfactual: the pre-rule distribution of stars' qualifying games scaled to the post-rule count. b = excess player-seasons in the window above 65 divided by the mean counterfactual mass per one-game bin in that window; m likewise for the window below. 95% CIs from 2,000 bootstrap resamples of both distributions.

Table 7: Healthy at-risk stars at team game 62: did they reach 65?

Slack at game 62	Pre: n	Pre: reached 65	Post: n	Post: reached 65	Fisher p
0-2	20	0.40	2	1.00	0.19
3-5	27	0.70	8	0.62	0.69
6-8	25	0.60	11	0.64	1.00

Note:

At risk: 0-8 games of slack at team game 62 (qualifying games so far plus games left minus 65). Healthy: played at least two of games 60-62. Reached: ≥ 65 qualifying games at season end. Fisher exact test of pre vs post.

Table 8: Post-rule change in the probability that an at-risk star reaches 65

Sample	n	Post n	Pre reach	Post reach	Post: est (SE)	MDE
All at-risk stars	116	34	0.56	0.53	-0.05 (0.10)	0.28
Healthy at game 62	93	21	0.58	0.67	0.06 (0.13)	0.35
Healthy, with current-season contention control	93	21	0.58	0.67	0.14 (0.13)	0.36
Healthy, slack 0-5	57	10	0.57	0.70	0.13 (0.17)	0.48

Note:

Linear probability models with slack-bin controls; SEs clustered by player. MDE at 80% power, in probability points.

Table 9: The maximal-effect bound on star mean qualifying games

Period	Stars per season	At risk per season	Share at risk	Did not reach	Bound, minimal crossing	Bound, play every game
Post-rule (3 seasons)	44.0	11.3	0.26	5.3	0.96	1.85
Pre-rule (8 seasons)	40.9	10.2	0.25	4.5	0.67	1.27

Note:

Minimal crossing: every at-risk star who fell short instead reaches exactly 65. Play every game: every at-risk star plays every remaining game. Both divided by the number of stars that season and averaged over seasons; units are games per star player-season.

Table 10: Healthy at-risk stars in the post-rule seasons: slack at game 62, outcome, return minutes, and stakes

season	player	slack_at_62	qualifying_games_62	contention_prior_season	reached_62	final_qualifying_games	last_absence_before_62	absences_before_62	minutes_lost_4_after_return	secured_season	status
2024	Andrew Wiggins	4	49	FALSE	TRUE	67	69	9	14, 12, 26, 20	FALSE	none identified
2024	Tyrese Haliburton	4	88	FALSE	TRUE	69	68	13	22, 22, 22, 20	TRUE	Base Rule: 2023 rookie extension worth 30% of cap instead of 25% with AD-NBA in 2024 (about \$48M); made AD-NBA Third Team
2024	Russell Westbrook	6	51	TRUE	FALSE	70	26	10	26, 26, 26, 20	TRUE	AD-NBA in 2024 would have made him eligible for a Designated Veteran (20%) extension, four years and about \$24M versus the three-year \$10M deal otherwise available; not selected
2024	LaMelo Ball	6	51	FALSE	FALSE	55	29	10	20, 20, 35, 20	FALSE	none identified
2024	Joel Embiid	6	51	FALSE	TRUE	70	51	10	24, 31, 26, 20	TRUE	Guaranteed for 2025 20 contract level to games played: 40% at 41 games, a further 20% at 51, full at 61; plus weight-in criteria; last years had become non-guaranteed after 50 missed games in 2022-23
2025	Scottie Barnes	3	88	FALSE	TRUE	65	59	14	26, 29, 30, 22	FALSE	2023 rookie extension projected at \$224.25M, rising to \$269.1M if Base Rule criteria are met; not selected
2025	Kyle Irving	4	49	FALSE	FALSE	62	52	13	42, 30, 20	FALSE	none identified
2025	Kyle Irving	4	49	FALSE	FALSE	49	56	12	27, 32, 40, 20	FALSE	none identified
2025	Christian Braun	4	50	TRUE	FALSE	68	54	10	24, 19, 32, 19	TRUE	none identified
2025	Jacoby Braun	7	52	FALSE	FALSE	63	59	10	34, 37, 40, 42	FALSE	none identified; super-max signed July 2023, so no evaluator
2025	Domantas Sabonis	8	52	FALSE	FALSE	59	56	10	24, 37, 32, 20	FALSE	none identified
2025	Stephen Curry	9	53	TRUE	TRUE	70	66	9	31, 31, 34, 25	TRUE	none identified
2026	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	1	46	TRUE	TRUE	65	68	14	20, 20, 32, 15	TRUE	none identified
2026	Karl-Anthony Towns	2	47	TRUE	TRUE	65	66	15	27, 27, 32, 20	TRUE	Base Rule already triggered by 2025 Defensive Player of the Year; no further stakes in 2026
2026	Karl-Anthony Towns	3	46	FALSE	TRUE	65	56	14	20, 20, 32, 15	TRUE	Base Rule already triggered by 2025 Defensive Player of the Year; no further stakes in 2026
2026	Vince Williams	4	46	FALSE	TRUE	65	36	14	20, 20, 36, 27	TRUE	Base Rule already triggered by 2025 Defensive Player of the Year; no further stakes in 2026
2026	Kyle Lowmyer	5	50	FALSE	FALSE	64	54	12	26, 32, 30, 20	TRUE	Base Rule already triggered by 2025 Defensive Player of the Year; no further stakes in 2026
2026	Anthony Edwards	6	51	TRUE	FALSE	60	67	10	30, 33, 30, 40	FALSE	Base Rule triggered by 2021 AD-NBA, a 2020 AD-NBA contract earned Designated Veteran criteria, but he lacks the years of service for a super-max extension until 2027; eligibility denied by arbitrator at 40
2026	Pauli Bamba	6	51	FALSE	TRUE	71	22	10	26, 24, 32, 25	FALSE	2023 rookie extension projected at \$20.25M, rising to \$27.1M with AD-NBA, MVP or DPOY in 2022-23
2026	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	6	51	TRUE	TRUE	68	60	11	24, 32, 35, 25	TRUE	Super-max signed July 2023, projected \$284.6M; no evaluator at stake
2026	Russell Westbrook	6	52	TRUE	TRUE	72	22	4	21, 32, 34, 20	TRUE	Three-year max extension signed 2023, projected \$10.2M; no evaluator at stake

Note:

At risk: 0-5 games of slack at team game 62; healthy: played at least two of games 60-62. Return minutes: minutes in the first line appearance after the player's last absence before team game 62. Statuses are hand-coded from press coverage and the CBA; criteria marked for verification in the row should be checked against 'Spikes' before use.

Table 11: Absence of stars who played the previous game, late season, by eligibility state

State	Pre: n	Pre: absent	Post: n	Post: absent	Change (SE)	Pre: with DNP row	Post: with DNP row
reachable	3436	7.1%	1337	9.1%	2.0 (0.9)	2.7%	2.1%
secured	1779	10.8%	623	12.4%	1.5 (1.5)	5.7%	2.1%
unreachable	1297	14.6%	461	16.1%	1.4 (2.0)	6.7%	2.4%

Note:

Games 56 onward, full team schedule, 2020-2021 excluded. Absent: did not play, whether or not ESPN printed a row. 'With DNP row': the part of the absence rate for which ESPN printed a row with a reason. Change in percentage points with a binomial SE.

Table 12: State x post-rule regressions of late-season absence, stars

Specification	Term	Est (SE)	p	MDE
state main effects + state x post	secured	0.006 (0.013)	0.61	0.036
state main effects + state x post	secured x post	-0.011 (0.019)	0.56	0.053
no-incentive + no-incentive x post	no incentive	-0.004 (0.012)	0.73	0.034
no-incentive + no-incentive x post	no incentive x post	-0.005 (0.019)	0.78	0.053

Note:

Player-season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. Reference state: reachable. MDE at 80% power. The unreachable state is omitted: within a player-season its games follow a long absence, so the within-player contrast is mechanically negative and the post interaction is identified from few transitions; Table 6a carries that state.

Table 13: Star-specific change in late-season absence at the 2017 policy and the 2023 rule

Window	Player-games	Est (SE)	95% CI	MDE
2014-2026: post-rule (2024-26) x star	24606	-0.019 (0.016)	[-0.050, 0.012]	0.044
2022-2026: post-rule (2024-26) x star	11807	-0.023 (0.015)	[-0.053, 0.008]	0.043
2014-2019: post-2017-policy (2018-19) x star	12799	0.010 (0.016)	[-0.022, 0.041]	0.045

Note:

Stars vs high-minute non-stars who played the previous game, games 56 onward, full schedule. Player, season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. MDE at 80% power.

Appendix figures

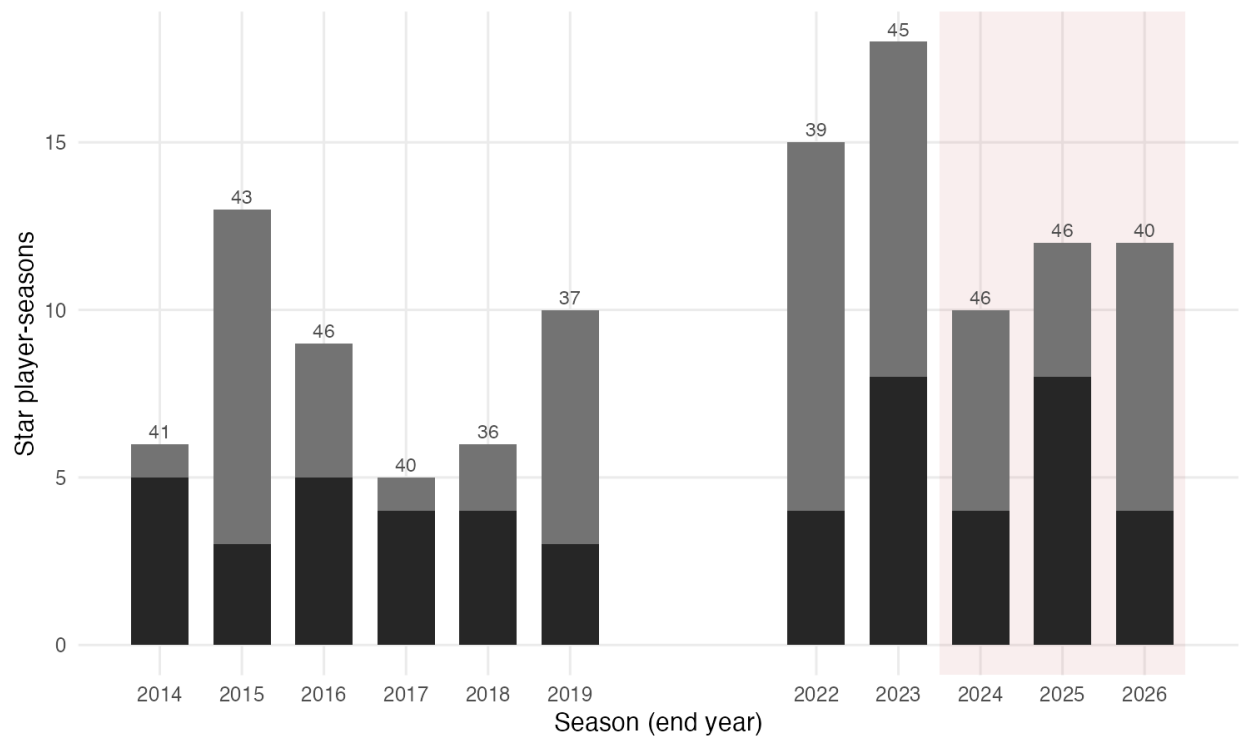


Figure 6: Stars at risk at team game 62 (slack 0-8), by season; black: at risk and did not reach 65; number above bar: stars that season.

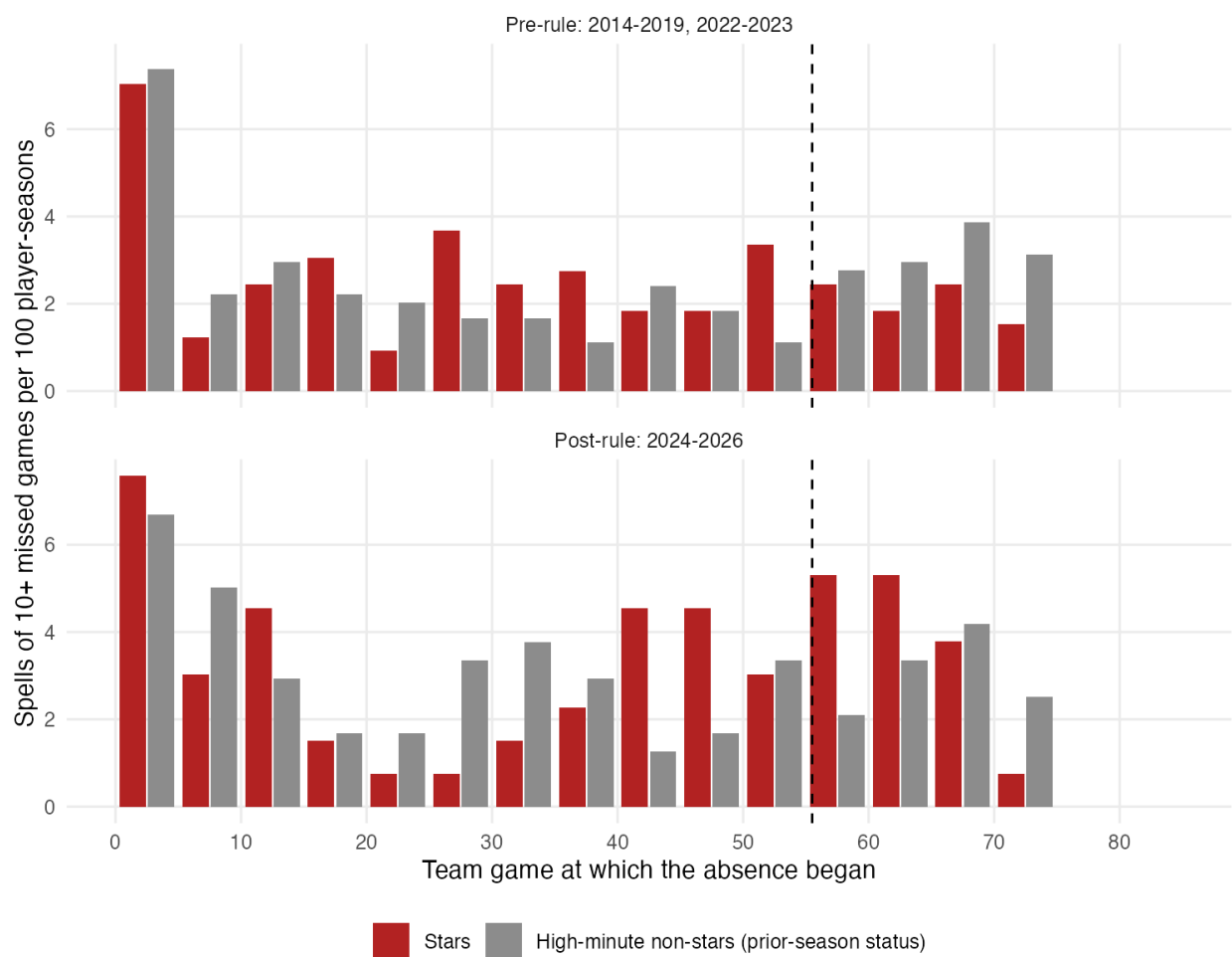


Figure 7: Team game at which spells of 10 or more missed games began, per 100 player-seasons, stars and control, before and after the rule.

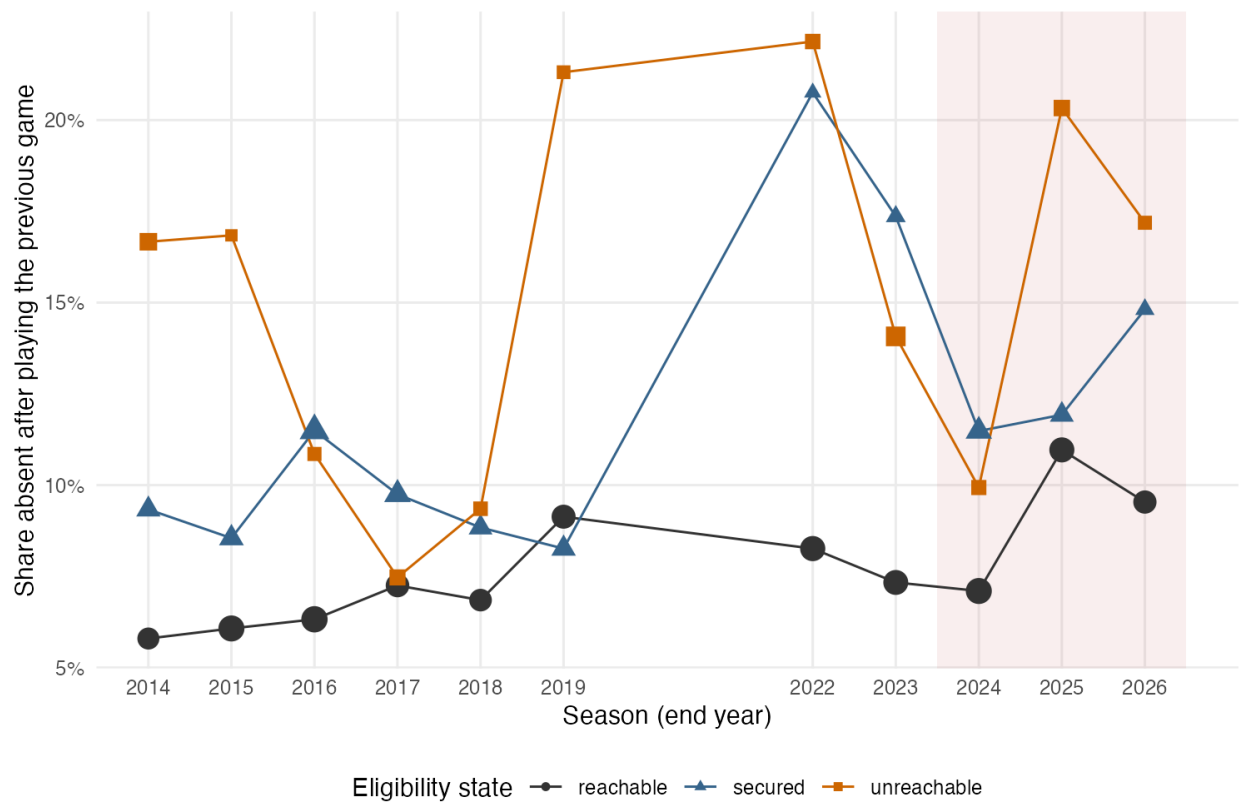


Figure 8: Late-season absence of stars who played the previous game, by eligibility state and season; point size is the number of player-games in the cell.

Appendix tables

Table 14: Star minus non-star late-season absence by season

Season	Full, ref 2023: est (SE)	MDE	Full, ref 2017: est (SE)	MDE	ESPN rows only, ref 2023: est (SE)	MDE
2014	NA	NA	NA	NA	0.023 (0.014)	0.038
2015	0.010 (0.020)	0.057	0.008 (0.019)	0.054	0.009 (0.014)	0.040
2016	0.001 (0.022)	0.062	-0.002 (0.021)	0.058	0.023 (0.015)	0.041
2017	0.006 (0.018)	0.049	0.000 (0.000)	0.000	0.018 (0.012)	0.034
2018	0.005 (0.020)	0.056	0.003 (0.019)	0.053	-0.002 (0.011)	0.032
2019	0.035 (0.022)	0.062	0.033 (0.022)	0.061	-0.001 (0.015)	0.043
2022	0.031 (0.020)	0.057	0.029 (0.021)	0.060	0.012 (0.013)	0.036
2023	0.000 (0.000)	0.000	-0.008 (0.021)	0.059	0.000 (0.000)	0.000
2024	-0.008 (0.018)	0.050	-0.010 (0.020)	0.055	-0.009 (0.008)	0.023
2025	-0.017 (0.025)	0.069	-0.019 (0.026)	0.074	-0.005 (0.014)	0.039
2026	-0.018 (0.024)	0.068	-0.020 (0.025)	0.071	-0.021 (0.010)	0.029

Note:

Coefficients on star x season; player, season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. 'ESPN rows only' reproduces the exploratory construction in which only games with an ESPN row enter.

Table 15: Minutes played by late-season stars, by slack: share of player-games (cell count)

Sample	Minutes	pre, not tight	pre, tight	post, not tight	post, tight
All	<15	0.018 (103)	0.010 (7)	0.007 (16)	0.000 (0)
All	15-19	0.030 (173)	0.031 (22)	0.010 (22)	0.011 (2)
All	20-22	0.037 (211)	0.042 (30)	0.026 (57)	0.043 (8)
All	23-30	0.243 (1385)	0.294 (209)	0.215 (470)	0.368 (68)
All	31+	0.671 (3823)	0.623 (442)	0.742 (1622)	0.578 (107)
Played each of previous 3 games	<15	0.013 (58)	0.013 (7)	0.004 (7)	0.000 (0)
Played each of previous 3 games	15-19	0.021 (98)	0.033 (17)	0.009 (15)	0.000 (0)
Played each of previous 3 games	20-22	0.031 (142)	0.034 (18)	0.026 (43)	0.034 (4)
Played each of previous 3 games	23-30	0.239 (1090)	0.295 (154)	0.202 (340)	0.325 (38)
Played each of previous 3 games	31+	0.696 (3176)	0.625 (326)	0.759 (1275)	0.641 (75)

Note:

Stars who played, games 56 onward, 2020-2021 excluded. Tight: 0-3 games of slack and 65 not yet secured. Cell counts in parentheses. Confounded by minute restrictions on players returning from injury.

Table 16: Spells of 10 or more consecutive missed games, stars and high-minute non-stars

Group	Period	Player-seasons	Spells	Spells per star-season	Star-seasons with a spell	Mean length	Games lost per star-season	Censored at season end	Reason: injury/illness	Reason: no row	Reason: rest or coach	Begin games 1-20	21-40	41-55	56-82
Stars	Pre-rule	327	127	0.39	33%	25.6	10.0	31%	30%	56%	11%	35%	25%	18%	21%
Stars	Post-rule	132	65	0.49	39%	22.2	11.0	34%	20%	77%	0%	34%	11%	25%	31%
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Pre-rule	542	213	0.39	34%	24.0	9.4	39%	32%	54%	12%	38%	16%	14%	32%
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Post-rule	239	111	0.46	38%	19.9	9.2	32%	32%	62%	3%	35%	25%	14%	26%

Note:

Full team schedule, 2020-2021 excluded. Reason taken from the first game in the spell for which ESPN printed a row; 'no row' spells have no ESPN row at any point.

Table 17: What ESPN says about late-season absences of stars who played the previous game

Period	Class	n	Share
Pre-rule	no row (reason unknown)	345	54.9%
Pre-rule	injury or illness	113	18.0%
Pre-rule	coach's decision	107	17.0%
Pre-rule	rest	52	8.3%
Pre-rule	other	11	1.8%
Post-rule	no row (reason unknown)	221	81.0%
Post-rule	injury or illness	41	15.0%
Post-rule	rest	7	2.6%
Post-rule	other	4	1.5%

Note:

Classes from the DNP reason string. Absences with no ESPN row carry no reason.

Table 18: Games played: ten star-seasons checked against Basketball-Reference

Season	Player	Reference games played	This paper: regular season	Raw ESPN count	Games under the rule (incl. Cup final)	Qualifying games	Status	Source
2024	Joel Embiid	39	39	39	39	39	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (ESPN game log, StatMuse); BBR not re-requested
2024	Tyrese Haliburton	69	69	71	70	69	match	cached BBR awards_2024.html (MVP and All-NBA voting tables, G column)
2023	Stephen Curry	56	56	56	56	56	match	cached BBR awards_2023.html (MVP voting table, G column)
2025	Luka Doncic	50	50	50	50	50	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (22 DAL + 28 LAL); BBR not re-requested
2024	Nikola Jokic	79	79	80	79	79	match	cached BBR awards_2024.html (MVP voting table, G column)
2023	LeBron James	55	55	56	55	55	match	cached BBR awards_2023.html (All-NBA voting table, G column)
2022	Kawhi Leonard	0	0	0	0	0	no ESPN rows; not in sample	missed the entire 2021-22 season (ACL); web lookup 2026-09-15
2024	Jimmy Butler	60	60	60	60	60	match	web lookup 2026-09-15; BBR not re-requested
2024	Donovan Mitchell	55	55	56	55	55	match	web lookup 2026-09-15 (StatMuse); BBR not re-requested
2026	Victor Wembanyama	64	64	67	65	65	match	cached BBR awards_2026.html (MVP, DPOY, All-NBA voting tables, G column)

Note:

Reference values from cached Basketball-Reference award-voting tables where available, otherwise from a web lookup on the date shown. Regular-season games exclude the All-Star game and the NBA Cup final, as Basketball-Reference does; the rule's count includes the Cup final.

Table 19: Flagged stars absent from the sample: no ESPN box-score row in the season

Season	Flagged stars with no ESPN appearance
2015	Andrew Bynum
2017	Chris Bosh; Kobe Bryant; Tim Duncan
2018	Chris Bosh; Kobe Bryant; Tim Duncan
2019	Kobe Bryant
2020	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; John Wall; Kevin Durant; Klay Thompson
2021	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; Klay Thompson
2022	Dirk Nowitzki; Dwyane Wade; Kawhi Leonard; Zion Williamson
2026	Kyrie Irving; Tyrese Haliburton

Note:

Retired players and players who missed the entire season. They do not enter any player-season count.

Table 20: Effect of removing All-Star and Rising Stars rows on star counts

Season	Stars	GP changed	QG changed	Mean GP, raw	Mean GP, clean	Mean QG, raw	Mean QG, clean	Crossed 65 only via exhibition
2014	41	18	10	60.7	60.3	58.2	57.9	0
2015	43	16	11	63.5	63.2	61.1	60.9	0
2016	46	20	16	69.5	69.1	66.4	66.0	0
2017	40	21	17	70.8	70.2	66.7	66.3	0
2018	36	18	15	64.7	64.2	62.6	62.2	0
2019	37	19	13	63.6	63.1	61.9	61.6	1
2022	39	15	10	58.5	58.1	56.9	56.7	0
2023	45	16	14	59.7	59.4	58.8	58.4	1
2024	46	19	14	65.5	65.0	64.8	64.5	0
2025	46	16	0	63.1	62.4	62.0	62.0	0
2026	40	18	0	56.1	54.8	54.4	54.4	0

Note:

Games played also exclude the NBA Cup final (a non-regular-season game for statistics); qualifying games include it, as the rule does.

Table 21: Decomposition of the 2023 to 2024 change in mean games: stayers, entrants and leavers

Outcome	Mean 2023 (n)	Mean 2024 (n)	Raw change	Stayers: n	Stayers 2023	Stayers 2024	Stayers change	Entrants 2024 (n)	Leavers 2023 (n)
Stars: games played	59.4 (45)	65.0 (46)	5.6	39	61.3	64.2	2.9	69.6 (7)	46.7 (6)
Stars: qualifying games	58.4 (45)	64.5 (46)	6.1	39	60.6	63.7	3.0	69.3 (7)	44.2 (6)
High-minute non-stars (prior season): games played	65.6 (82)	66.1 (90)	0.6	50	69.7	66.0	-3.8	66.4 (40)	59.1 (32)

Note:

Stayers are players in the group in both seasons; entrants are 2024 members who were not members in 2023; leavers are 2023 members who were not members in 2024. The within-player event-study coefficient is identified from stayers.

Table 22: Fixed-cohort difference-in-differences for each pair of adjacent seasons, games played

Seasons	Stars (n)	Stars: first, second	Controls (n)	Controls: first, second	DiD: est (SE)	p	MDE
2015->2016	42	64.7, 67.5	85	66.3, 65.0	4.15 (3.77)	0.27	10.6
2016->2017	42	70.5, 69.0	69	67.4, 66.2	-0.31 (3.06)	0.92	8.6
2017->2018	39	70.8, 63.3	74	66.2, 62.2	-3.59 (3.89)	0.36	10.9
2018->2019	36	64.2, 63.3	72	63.9, 63.3	-0.31 (5.16)	0.95	14.5
2022->2023	38	58.4, 60.1	73	61.1, 63.7	-0.92 (3.93)	0.82	11.0
2023->2024	44	60.5, 63.3	80	65.8, 63.9	4.66 (3.44)	0.18	9.6
2024->2025	46	65.0, 63.0	86	66.9, 61.0	3.91 (3.32)	0.24	9.3
2025->2026	43	62.5, 52.9	79	61.5, 57.0	-5.16 (4.64)	0.27	13.0

Note:

Groups fixed at their status in the first season of the pair; players present in both seasons; player and season fixed effects; SEs clustered by player. The 2023 to 2024 row is the year the rule took effect.

Table 23: The maximal-effect bound under alternative definitions of the at-risk population

Slack measured at game	Window	Period	At risk per season	Share of stars	Did not reach	Bound, minimal crossing	Bound, play every game
55	0-12	Pre-rule	16.8	0.41	6.0	1.07	2.42
55	0-12	Post-rule	20.7	0.47	7.3	1.71	3.79
55	0-8	Pre-rule	9.5	0.23	4.6	0.89	1.55
55	0-8	Post-rule	9.7	0.22	5.3	1.30	2.10
62	0-12	Pre-rule	17.9	0.44	5.4	0.75	2.05
62	0-12	Post-rule	20.3	0.46	5.7	0.99	2.55
62	0-8	Pre-rule	10.2	0.25	4.5	0.67	1.28
62	0-8	Post-rule	11.3	0.26	5.3	0.98	1.83

Note:

Same construction as Table 5c with slack measured at team game 62 or 55 and the window widened to 0-12 games.

Table 24: Finishing at exactly 65 qualifying games among stars who reached the line

Sample	Period	n	Finished at exactly 65	Share	Mean final qualifying games	Fisher p
all star reachers	Pre-rule	192	9	0.05	73.7	0.16
all star reachers	Post-rule	75	7	0.09	72.7	0.16
at-risk reachers	Pre-rule	46	8	0.17	67.3	0.19
at-risk reachers	Post-rule	18	6	0.33	67.8	0.19
healthy at-risk reachers	Pre-rule	42	8	0.19	67.1	0.27
healthy at-risk reachers	Post-rule	14	5	0.36	67.9	0.27

Note:

At-risk: 0-8 games of slack at team game 62. Healthy: played at least two of games 60-62. Fisher exact test of pre vs post within sample.

Table 25: Final qualifying games of at-risk stars who reached 65

Final qualifying games	Pre: n	Pre: share	Post: n	Post: share
65	8	0.17	6	0.33
66	13	0.28	0	0.00
67	7	0.15	2	0.11
68	8	0.17	3	0.17
69	3	0.07	1	0.06
70	2	0.04	4	0.22
71	3	0.07	1	0.06
72	2	0.04	1	0.06

Table 26: Share of appearances lasting at least 20 minutes: stars relative to the control group

Season	Stars: share 20+ min	Control: share 20+ min	All games: star x season (SE)	MDE	Late season: star x season (SE)	MDE
2015	0.946	0.906	-0.025 (0.024)	0.068	-0.073 (0.032)	0.089
2016	0.941	0.875	-0.001 (0.020)	0.056	-0.031 (0.025)	0.069
2017	0.932	0.913	0.001 (0.022)	0.062	0.007 (0.024)	0.068
2018	0.960	0.916	0.018 (0.019)	0.052	0.017 (0.024)	0.068
2019	0.964	0.923	0.017 (0.019)	0.053	-0.002 (0.028)	0.078
2022	0.970	0.937	-0.013 (0.021)	0.059	-0.000 (0.026)	0.073
2024	0.985	0.903	0.043 (0.016)	0.044	0.072 (0.024)	0.067
2025	0.984	0.922	0.040 (0.013)	0.035	0.057 (0.016)	0.044
2026	0.981	0.912	0.055 (0.016)	0.044	0.080 (0.020)	0.056

Note:

Player-games in which the player appeared, stars and lagged high-minute non-stars, 2015-2026 excluding 2020-2021. Coefficients on star x season relative to 2023; player, season and team-game-number fixed effects; SEs clustered by player.

Table 27: Long absences beginning in the late-season window, before and after the rule

Group	Period	Spells	Beginning at game 56+	Share	Fisher p (pre vs post)
Stars	Pre-rule	127		27	0.21
Stars	Post-rule	65		20	0.31
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Pre-rule	213		69	0.32
High-minute non-stars (prior season)	Post-rule	111		29	0.26

Note:

Difference in shares, stars minus control, post minus pre: 0.158 with bootstrap 95% interval [-0.012, 0.329] from 2,000 resamples of spells within group and period.

Table 28: ESPN box-score rows against Basketball-Reference did-not-play and inactive lists, sample games

Season	Game	ESPN rows	BBR box rows	ESPN rows found in BBR box	ESPN DNP rows	Of which BBR did-not-play	BBR inactive	BBR inactive with an ESPN row	Star with no ESPN row	On BBR inactive list
2015	2014-12-03	26	68	26	6	6	3	0	DeMar DeRozan	TRUE
2017	2016-12-28	26	68	26	7	7	4	0	Damian Lillard	TRUE
2019	2018-11-15	25	67	25	4	4	8	0	Pau Gasol	TRUE
2023	2023-01-31	28	70	28	8	8	6	0	Zion Williamson	TRUE
2024	2024-01-15	25	67	25	7	7	9	0	Jaylen Brown	TRUE
2025	2025-03-15	25	67	25	3	3	11	0	Ja Morant	TRUE
2026	2026-03-07	26	68	26	5	5	10	0	Jaren Jackson Jr.	TRUE

Note:
One game per season, chosen so that a star has an ESPN no-row absence. BBR box scores list did-not-play and did-not-dress players inside the box and inactive players below it.